



Big country

FRANCE IS THE LARGEST COUNTRY in Western Europe. It mostly consists of flat plains but there are some mountainous areas including the Pyrenees in the south, the Massif Central in the center, and the Alps in the east. France also administers some overseas territories left over from colonial times.

MODERN MONUMENT

The *Grand Arche* is a striking 35-story office block. It was one of a number of buildings commissioned at the end of the 20th century to symbolize France's role in art, politics, and the world economy. It is situated in Paris's La Defense district, home to 14 of France's top 20 corporations.



At the top of the building is a public gallery, which looks out onto spectacular views of Paris.



APPRECIATING THE ARTS

France has a long tradition of distinguished artists and an appreciation for the arts is instilled in French children from an early age. Art education is a compulsory part of the French school curriculum for children aged 5-15. They are taught both how to enjoy and understand art, and how to produce artworks of their own.



FILM FESTIVAL

Cannes' population is just under 70,000 but swells to almost three times this number during the annual international film festival every May. The town is situated on the French Riviera in the south of France and is also a popular destination during the summer months for both French and foreign tourists drawn to its mild climate and beautiful beaches.